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Marriage relationships in the double descent system of the Afikpo Ibo of southeastern Nigeria

Author(S): Ottenberg, Phoebe**Document Type:** Book**Original Page:** 267**Culture (OWC):** Igbo (FF26)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Western Africa**Field Date:** 1951-1953**Coverage Date:** Not Specified**Place Coverage:** Africa**Section Title(S)**Factors Promoting Marital Stability in Other African Societies

Another practice that is said to promote marital stability in some African societies is cross-cousin marriage. This is mentioned by Ames for the Wolof,⁴ Schapera for the Kgatla,⁵ Richards for the Bemba,⁶ and Fortes for the Ashanti.⁷ In their statements the factors both of jural and conjugal stability seem to be present, though Fortes notes that younger Ashanti show some distaste for this type of marriage.⁸ Contrary to the picture given for other societies, Mitchell writes of the Yao that they consider marriage between cross-cousins an unstable type of relationship, attributing this to the continuance of a joking  relationship that existed before.¹ Again, the implications of cross-cousin marriage for marital stability are complex, involving a detailed analysis of the social structure of a society under consideration, as well as statistical documentation.

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⁴Ames, 1953, pp. 45–46.

⁵Schapera, 1940, p. 41; 1950, p. 151.

⁶Richards, 1950, p. 228.

⁷Fortes, 1950, pp. 279, 281, 282. However, Rattray (1927, pp. 323, 326) stresses the importance of the perpetuation of names within the clan and economic considerations in this type of marriage.

⁸Fortes, 1950, p. 281.

¹Mitchell, 1951, p. 336. Ames (1953, p. 48) also mentions the continuance of a **joking relationship** as a source of friction in cousin marriage.

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